Charity Partner Standards Review

A structured review of a charitable organization against eleven evidence-based criteria — used to decide whether to begin a fundraising engagement, and to review an organization already under engagement against the same bar.

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This is a fillable form. Tap or click any box or field to complete it on a phone, tablet or computer. To keep your answers, save the file from your PDF app: on iPhone/iPad use the share icon, then “Save to Files” (or open it in Books); on Android use “Save a copy” in Acrobat or a PDF editor; in a desktop browser or Acrobat use “Save as” / download. Google Drive’s built-in preview is read-only — open the file in a PDF editor first.

Work through every criterion in order. For each one, gather the evidence under Collect, compare it against Meets the standard and Watch for, then record a rating and your findings. The form is not weighted toward either use: for a prospective organization it is a go / no-go screen; for a current one it is a periodic audit against the standard it was accepted on. A single Fails is a blocker. Rate N/A only with a written reason.

Meets — evidence present and adequate · Minor gaps — mostly there, small fixes · Material concern — real weakness, needs a plan and a re-check · Fails — absent or deficient, a blocker · N/A — not applicable (say why)

ORGANIZATION UNDER REVIEW

LEGAL NAME / DBA

EIN

STATE OF INCORPORATION / YEAR FOUNDED

PRINCIPAL ADDRESS

PRIMARY CONTACT — NAME & TITLE

CONTACT EMAIL & PHONE

WEBSITE

CHARITY WATCHDOG PROFILES SEEN

PURPOSE OF REVIEW

- ○ Prospective — considering an engagement
- ○ Current — periodic review

FUNDRAISING ACTIVITY IN SCOPE

☐ Door-to-door ☐ Street / canvassing ☐ Events & booths ☐ Telephone ☐ Digital ☐ Other

STATES / LOCALITIES WHERE SOLICITATION WILL OCCUR

REVIEWER

DATE OF REVIEW / PERIOD COVERED

PART A — LEGAL & REGULATORY STANDING

1 Tax-exempt status: 501(c)(3) determination & IRS Form 990

Confirms the organization is a recognised tax-exempt public charity in good standing, and that its finances hold up to inspection — donors and property owners routinely ask a rep to prove both.

COLLECT

- [ ] The IRS determination letter granting 501(c)(3) status, in the organization's current legal name.
- [ ] A screenshot of the organization's active listing in IRS Tax Exempt Organization Search, and confirmation it is not on the automatic-revocation list.
- [ ] The three most recent Forms 990 as filed (990, 990-EZ or 990-N as applicable), with all schedules.
- [ ] The most recent audited or reviewed financial statements, and the board-approved annual budget.
- [ ] If the organization operates under a fiscal sponsor: the written fiscal-sponsorship agreement and the sponsor's own status.
- [ ] Any state income / franchise / sales-tax exemption confirmations relevant to where it operates.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Valid determination letter; classified as a public charity (e.g. 509(a)(1) or (a)(2)), not a private foundation, unless the engagement specifically contemplates otherwise.
- [ ] Name and EIN match across the letter, the 990s, the website and the bank details.
- [ ] 990s filed on time; the full form (not just the 990-N postcard) where revenue requires it.
- [ ] Program-service expense is a clear majority of total expense; fundraising and management/general are reasonable and stable year to year.
- [ ] Revenue is stable or growing; an operating reserve exists; no going-concern language in the audit.
- [ ] Executive compensation is disclosed and reasonable for the organization's size and region.
- [ ] Governance section of the 990 is clean: independent board majority, and conflict-of-interest, whistleblower and document-retention policies in place; the board reviews the 990 before filing.
- [ ] Schedule G (fundraising) and Schedule L (interested-person transactions) contain nothing unexplained.

WATCH FOR

- Cannot produce the determination letter; status is "pending"; fiscal sponsorship with no written agreement.
- On the automatic-revocation list, lapsed, or recently reinstated after revocation with no clear explanation.
- Missing or late 990 years; a 990-N filed while revenue clearly exceeds the threshold.
- Fundraising cost is a large or fast-rising share of contributions; multi-year deficits; negative net assets.
- Payments to companies tied to board or staff; loans to officers; large unexplained "miscellaneous" lines.
- One donor or grant is effectively the entire budget; public impact claims that the 990 does not support.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

2 Charitable-solicitation registration, fundraiser bond & permits

Paid, in-person fundraising is regulated state by state and often locally. This criterion confirms the organization — and the fundraising firm acting for it — is registered, bonded and permitted everywhere the work will happen. Requirements, dollar thresholds and exemptions vary widely by jurisdiction and change often — treat the items below as prompts and confirm the current rule for each state and locality with qualified counsel.

COLLECT

- [ ] Proof of charitable-solicitation registration in every state where the organization solicits (most states require it; some exempt very small organizations).
- [ ] Registration or licensing of the professional fundraiser / professional solicitor / fundraising counsel as each state defines those roles.
- [ ] The surety bond on file wherever a state requires paid solicitors to be bonded — amount, carrier and expiration date.
- [ ] The written contract between the organization and the fundraising firm, filed with the state where required, carrying the state-mandated disclosures.
- [ ] Local permits — canvassing, peddler, solicitation or door-to-door permits — for the specific municipalities to be worked.
- [ ] Copies of the organization's annual financial reports to state charity regulators for the last two years.
- [ ] Any raffle, gaming or sales-tax permits if those activities occur alongside solicitation.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] All registrations are active, unexpired, and renewals are tracked on a calendar with a named owner.
- [ ] Fundraiser registration and bond are current; the bond amount meets or exceeds the state minimum.
- [ ] State annual financial reports have been filed for every required year.
- [ ] The charity–firm contract carries the state-mandated clauses — the charity's right to cancel the contract, the percentage or fee split stated plainly, and the paid-solicitor disclosure reps must give at the point of solicitation.
- [ ] The organization can name the person responsible for solicitation compliance and show how new jurisdictions get cleared before work starts.
- [ ] No open or recent enforcement matters with any state attorney general or charity regulator.

WATCH FOR

- "We don't need to register" with no written legal basis; active solicitation in states with no registration on file.
- Expired or lapsed registrations; unfiled state annual reports.
- No bond where one is required, or a bond past its expiration date.
- No written contract, or one missing the state-mandated disclosures.
- Any history of fines, cease-and-desist orders, or an assurance of voluntary compliance with a state regulator over solicitation practices.
- Pressure to start in the field before permits or registrations are confirmed.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

PART B — PUBLIC IDENTITY & COMMUNICATIONS

3 Website

The first place a donor checks after a doorstep conversation. It has to confirm the organization is real, current and transparent within about thirty seconds.

COLLECT

- [ ] The live URL, plus a WHOIS / domain-registration check showing the organization owns the domain.
- [ ] The About / Leadership / Board page, the financials / annual report page, and the donate flow.
- [ ] The privacy policy and any donor-privacy statement.
- [ ] The date of the most recent news / blog / event post.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Organization-owned domain; loads over HTTPS; design consistent with its other materials.
- [ ] Clear statement of mission, the specific programs, who is served and where.
- [ ] Named leadership and board with short bios; a real address and a working phone and email.
- [ ] Financial transparency on the site: annual report, audited financials or the 990, and/or an impact report.
- [ ] A secure donate path that explains how gifts are used and offers a recurring option; card processing on a reputable platform.
- [ ] Updated within roughly the last quarter; third-party trust marks (Candid Seal, Charity Navigator, BBB) that resolve to a real profile.

WATCH FOR

- Domain registered very recently or to an unrelated party; no HTTPS; broken or placeholder pages.
- No named leadership, no address, contact only through a form.
- No financial information anywhere; donate button links to a personal payment handle.
- Nothing updated in a year or more; impact numbers with no source; claims that conflict with the 990.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

4 Social media

Shows whether the organization is active, whether real people engage with it, and how it handles questions and criticism in public.

COLLECT

- [ ] Handles for each platform, linked from the website so they are verifiably official.
- [ ] Screenshots of the last month or two of posts on each active account.
- [ ] A follower / engagement snapshot per platform.
- [ ] Examples of how the organization has replied to a public question or complaint.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Consistent name, handle and branding across platforms, matching the website.
- [ ] Posts at least monthly — ideally weekly — with genuine program content, not only donation asks.
- [ ] Engagement is proportionate to the audience and looks organic; the organization answers questions and complaints professionally, in public.
- [ ] No misleading urgency, no fabricated matching-gift claims, tone appropriate to a charity.

WATCH FOR

- Dormant or abandoned accounts; last post long ago.
- Follower count wildly out of line with engagement (purchased following).
- Unanswered complaints, or defensive / hostile replies.
- Content that contradicts the organization's own program claims or filings.
- No presence at all for an organization that solicits the general public.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

5 Newsletters & donor communications

Regular reporting back to donors is the clearest sign an organization treats a gift as the start of a relationship rather than the end of a transaction.

COLLECT

- ☐ The last three to four issues of the email and/or print newsletter.
- ☐ The publishing cadence (monthly, quarterly) and the list size / open rates if the organization will share them.
- ☐ A sample gift acknowledgement and a sample year-end tax receipt.
- ☐ The subscribe mechanism and the unsubscribe / preference process.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- ☐ Predictable cadence with several recent issues; content is program and impact reporting, not a continuous appeal.
- ☐ Acknowledgements are prompt and carry the IRS-required elements — the organization's name, the amount of cash or a description of any non-cash gift, and whether any goods or services were given in return (with a good-faith value if so).
- ☐ Clear, honoured unsubscribe; a stated approach to how often the organization contacts donors.
- ☐ Stories about beneficiaries are told with dignity and, where identifiable, with consent.

WATCH FOR

- No donor communication at all, or nothing sent in the last year.
- Every message is an emergency appeal; no reporting on what prior gifts achieved.
- Acknowledgements missing required elements, or not sent.
- No way to opt out, or opt-outs ignored.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

6 Letterhead & official stationery

Field reps carry a letter of authorization on the organization's letterhead; donors and property owners ask to see it. The stationery set is a quick read on organizational maturity and on whether the engagement is properly documented.

COLLECT

- ☐ The letterhead template (print and digital).

- [ ] A current, signed authorization letter on letterhead naming the fundraising firm, the territory and the campaign date range.
- [ ] The gift-acknowledgement / receipt template.
- [ ] Rep-facing identification: ID badge and business-card templates, and any branded canvassing materials.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Professionally designed letterhead showing the legal name, address, phone, website, EIN and a 501(c)(3) line.
- [ ] Authorization letter is dated, signed by an officer, and specific about who is authorized to do what, where and when.
- [ ] Acknowledgement text includes every IRS-required element for substantiation.
- [ ] Branding on the letterhead, website and social accounts is visibly the same organization.

WATCH FOR

- No letterhead, or an informal / inconsistent template.
- No authorization letter, or one that is undated, unsigned, or generic about scope.
- Receipt text missing required IRS language.
- Letterhead shows a different legal name or address than the determination letter.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

7 Public relations & reputation

Independent coverage and watchdog ratings are borrowed credibility a rep can point to. A reputation search is also where solicitation complaints and regulator actions surface before they become the firm's problem.

COLLECT

- [ ] The media / press page, recent press releases, and a list of earned coverage (articles, broadcast, podcasts).
- [ ] A named media contact or agency, and any crisis-communications plan or designated spokesperson.
- [ ] Results of an independent reputation search — news, court records, state regulator actions, forums, complaint sites, BBB complaints, employee-review sites.
- [ ] Watchdog profiles: Charity Navigator score, Candid / GuideStar Seal of Transparency level, BBB Wise Giving Alliance standards result, CharityWatch grade.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Some verifiable earned media or third-party recognition, not only paid placements.
- [ ] Watchdog profiles are claimed, complete and rate acceptably; BBB Wise Giving standards met.
- [ ] No material litigation, no regulator actions, no pattern of donor or consumer complaints.
- [ ] A named person owns fundraising-related inquiries and complaints, with a plan for handling a news query.

WATCH FOR

- No third-party footprint at all, or only sponsored content.
- Low watchdog ratings, or profiles that are unclaimed and thin.
- Active lawsuits, attorney-general inquiries, or coverage alleging misuse of funds or deceptive solicitation.
- Recurring public complaints about aggressive or misleading fundraising.
- No spokesperson and no plan — every inquiry would default to the fundraising firm.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

PART C — PROGRAMS & EVIDENCE

8 Program content & documented outcomes

The specific, checkable description of what the organization does — "counselling for 77 veterans this year," not "helping those in need." This is the content reps are trained on and the content that has to hold up if a donor probes.

COLLECT

- [ ] A written description of every program: who it serves, eligibility, what is delivered, where, by whom, and at what volume.
- [ ] A logic model or theory of change — inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes.
- [ ] Current-year output numbers (people served, sessions, meals, beds, grants) and a note on how each is counted.
- [ ] Outcome measures — what changed for the people served, how it is measured, over what period.
- [ ] The most recent impact / annual report and any independent program evaluation.
- [ ] Enough of the underlying data source (case-management system, intake records, surveys) to see the headline numbers are real.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Every public impact claim traces to a specific program and a countable source.
- [ ] Outputs and outcomes are distinguished — e.g. "1,200 counselling sessions delivered to 77 veterans" and "68% reported reduced symptoms at 90 days."
- [ ] The numbers are internally consistent across program documents, the website, social posts and the 990.
- [ ] Programs match the exempt purpose in the determination letter.
- [ ] Cost per person served / per outcome is explainable and reasonable.

WATCH FOR

- Vague mission language, no specific programs, no numbers.
- Large round claims ("changed thousands of lives") with no denominator and no source.
- Figures that conflict between documents.
- The "program" is mostly awareness or marketing, with little direct service.
- Staff cannot say how a headline number was counted.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

9 Testimonials & third-party validation

Independent voices — beneficiaries, partner institutions, funders — corroborate the program story. Funders in particular have done their own diligence, so their involvement is a useful shortcut.

COLLECT

- [ ] Beneficiary testimonials with consent / release on file, ideally attributable or with verifiable context.

- [ ] Donor and volunteer testimonials.
- [ ] A partner list — other nonprofits, agencies, hospitals, schools, employers — with a contact who will confirm the relationship.
- [ ] A funder list (foundations, government grants), plus awards, accreditations and coalition memberships.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Testimonials are specific and attributable, not anonymous one-liners.
- [ ] At least a few named institutional partners or funders who can be contacted for a reference.
- [ ] Consent / releases on file for anyone featured, especially minors or patients.
- [ ] Third-party validation is recent (last year or two), not a single decade-old award.

WATCH FOR

- Only anonymous, generic quotes; stock imagery presented as beneficiaries.
- No institutional partners or funders; unable to supply any reference.
- Testimonials that cannot be corroborated or that read as written in-house.
- Identifiable vulnerable people featured with no evidence of consent.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

PART D — ORGANIZATIONAL CLARITY

10 Defined structure, stats, facts & figures

A single fact sheet the organization can stand behind: governance, leadership, the key numbers, and — for a current partner — a clean record of what past campaigns actually produced.

COLLECT

- [ ] An org chart covering governance and staff.
- [ ] Board roster: names, outside affiliations, roles, terms and committee assignments; confirmation the board meets and keeps minutes.
- [ ] Leadership bios with tenure for the executive director / CEO and senior staff.
- [ ] Bylaws and the key governance policies — conflict of interest (signed annually), whistleblower, document retention, gift acceptance, financial controls.
- [ ] A facts block: legal name, DBA, EIN, state of incorporation, year founded, fiscal year end, staff headcount, volunteer count, annual operating budget, service area, number served per year.
- [ ] For a current partner: historical fundraising results — funds raised, donors acquired, retention, cost ratio — each with a date range and the internal system it came from.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- [ ] Every fact above is available on request and is consistent with the 990 and the website.
- [ ] Independent board majority; more than three directors; not family-controlled; the same person is not chair, treasurer and executive director.
- [ ] Documented internal financial controls — dual signature, bank reconciliation, budget-versus-actual reporting to the board.
- [ ] A named person on the organization's side owns the fundraising relationship.
- [ ] For current partners: results are scoped (period, campaign, geography) and pulled from a named system, not recalled from memory.

WATCH FOR

- No org chart or no current board list.
- Tiny or family board; officers also paid as board members.
- No bylaws, no policies, no minutes.
- Facts that change between conversations or do not match the filings.
- For current partners: no clean data on what previous campaigns raised or cost.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

PART E — FUNDRAISING OVERSIGHT

11 Representative management & field conduct

The engagement puts people on the street speaking for the organization. This criterion checks that the relationship is documented, that reps have approved messaging and identification, and that complaints have somewhere to go.

COLLECT

- ☐ The written agreement / statement of work between the organization and the fundraising firm: scope, territory, dates, supervision, compensation basis, required disclosures, termination, indemnification, insurance, data ownership, brand use.
- ☐ A code of conduct for anyone soliciting in the organization's name.
- ☐ The approved script and FAQ, and the list of what reps may and may not say (no guaranteed outcomes; disclose paid-solicitor status and the fee arrangement where required).
- ☐ Rep identification: badges, branded materials, and a public verification path (phone line or web page) to confirm a rep is authorized.
- ☐ Donor-data handling: what is collected, how it is transmitted, retention, do-not-contact / suppression process, card-data handling, breach procedure.
- ☐ Complaint handling: intake channel, response-time commitment, who investigates, how findings feed back to the firm, and the triggers for discipline or termination.
- ☐ The organization's designated relationship owner and escalation contacts, including after hours.
- ☐ Who speaks for the organization to the press or on social media if a fundraising incident draws attention, and how that ties back to the firm.
- ☐ Training the organization requires or provides, and any quality checks it runs (field checks, mystery donations, social listening).
- ☐ Insurance the organization carries or requires — general liability, directors & officers — and whether the firm must name the organization as additional insured.

MEETS THE STANDARD

- ☐ A signed, current contract covering all of the above; both sides can produce it.
- ☐ Written code of conduct and approved messaging; disclosure practice matches the rules for every state worked.
- ☐ A working public verification path for reps.
- ☐ Documented complaint process with named owners and timelines, and evidence it has actually been used.
- ☐ The organization actively monitors field conduct rather than delegating it entirely.
- ☐ Clean donor-data pipeline; suppression / do-not-contact honoured; card data never handled outside policy.

WATCH FOR

- Handshake deal, expired contract, or a contract that offloads all compliance onto the firm.
- No code of conduct; scripts that promise outcomes, hide paid-solicitor status, or apply pressure.
- No way for a donor to verify a rep is legitimate.
- Complaints have nowhere to go; no response commitment; no feedback loop to the firm.
- The organization “does not get involved” in how its name is used in the field.
- Donor data sent in plain text; no suppression process; card details captured on paper.

RATING ○ Meets ○ Minor ○ Concern ○ Fails ○ N/A

FINDINGS & EVIDENCE REVIEWED

FINDINGS & DETERMINATION

BLOCKERS — EVERY CRITERION RATED "FAILS"

REMEDIATION ITEMS — "MATERIAL CONCERN" AND "MINOR GAPS"

ITEM	OWNER	DUE	RE-CHECK

IF PROSPECTIVE

- ○ Proceed
- ○ Proceed with conditions
- ○ Hold pending fixes / remediation
- ○ Decline

IF CURRENT PARTNER

- ○ Continue
- ○ Continue with corrective-action plan
- ○ Suspend pending remediation
- ○ Begin exit

RATIONALE / CONDITIONS

REVIEWED BY / DATE

APPROVED BY / DATE

NEXT REVIEW

FILE REFERENCE

Internal screening tool, not legal advice. Charitable-solicitation registration, fundraiser bonding, disclosure language and permit rules are specific to each state and locality and change over time — confirm current requirements with qualified counsel, and the organization’s own financial position with its accountant.